parameters. But he surprised us all with his versatility when we were preparing for the Vikas ground test at SEP, Vernon. The SEP protocol had it that everything right from the smallest component of the engine we put together should be in conformance with what they tested on their campus.

Going by the specifications, the nozzle divergent of the engine should have a zirconium oxide coating; ours did not have it. We had seen it in Vernon how SEP would do it, but we had never done it ourselves. Giving a component a coating may sound a simple task, but making a microscopically uniform coating of the material over a flaring nozzle took some practice to perfect. It involved rotating the nozzle, and at the same time moving it forward and backward. The speed of the rotation and the lateral movement had to be accurate to ensure an even coating. DS did for us in a couple of months what the French must have taken years to perfect.

As work began on the Mahendragiri project, an English magazine published a story saying ISRO's integrated test complex would spell the end of the endangered lion-tailed monkey in Mahendragiri. It was partly our mistake identifying the place as Mahendragiri when the test stand was at Podigai, a hill south of Mahendragiri. The lion-tailed monkeys were found beyond Mahendragiri, towards the Kadukkaraithodu Hill, which was further north. I arranged a visit for the journalist from the magazine who was soon convinced that no monkey would be unhappy with our test facility.

Those who cried wolf about ISRO causing environmental degradation in Mahendragiri were soon silenced—not by any reaction from us, but by some proactive afforestation. ISRO taking over the forest land facilitated natural regeneration of the forest, now that the villagers were not entering the area. A couple of our engineers, Chandran and Thangaraj, who were passionate and knowledgeable about flora and fauna were given, besides their scientific assignment, the responsibility of overseeing an afforestation programme.

I realised there were no coconut palms in the vicinity (even though the Haldane Coconut Research Centre was very much there). In Trivandrum, we were used to coconut palms. Besides their soothing presence, they yielded a steady supply of coconuts to the VSSC canteen in Trivandrum so